

Made That Way: where it could go

Written 20 September 2026. This is the content for the PDF; the PDF itself comes next round.

What's in here: what other quiz and trivia apps get right and wrong, every idea worth writing down (including the impractical ones), the frameworks used to sort them, the insights that came out, a ranked list of what to build, and three prompts for testing the quiz as three different people.

1. How this was put together

1. **Study the field.** Ten quiz, trivia and learning apps, including two that died, for what worked, what wore thin and why.
 2. **Empty the drawer.** Write down every idea, including the ones that can't be built, because a wild idea usually contains a small buildable one.
 3. **Sort with frameworks.** The Hooked model (trigger, action, reward, investment) for habit; Octalysis for which drives are being used; Jobs to be Done for why someone opens this at all; Kano for what's expected against what delights; RICE for what to build first.
 4. **Distil.** Turn the ideas into a short list of insights, then into features with a size on each.
 5. **Test as three people.** Persona prompts, so someone else's agent (or a person) can play and report back.
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2. What the field teaches

Duolingo

Its streak is the most successful habit device in consumer software, and the company writes openly about why it designs what it does. In 2025 it replaced hearts, lost on every mistake, with energy, because beginners were twice as likely to run out of hearts mid-lesson, and mistakes are part of learning. In 2022 it replaced its skill tree with a single path, because learners didn't know what to do next.

Take: punish nothing that is part of learning. Give one obvious next thing to do.

Careful: its notification pressure is a running joke, and the energy change drew a petition. Pressure works until people notice being pressured.

Wordle

One puzzle a day, the same for everyone, thirty seconds, a share grid that gives nothing away. Bought by the New York Times in 2022.

Take: scarcity plus a shareable result beats endless play. Our daily question is the same shape, and its share card is a natural next step.

Kahoot

Built for a room: a big screen, a countdown, points for speed, a podium. Joy comes from other people, not the questions.

Take: speed scoring creates urgency (we already have it). A room mode is a real direction later.

Trivia Crack

Categories as a wheel, characters to collect, opponents to beat. Category choice is the hook: people play the topics they like and feel clever.

Take: choosing topics raises engagement, which is what we built. Its pressure to buy spins is what we should not copy.

HQ Trivia (died February 2020)

A live nightly show with real money. Enormous at first, gone when the funding stopped: it needed a crowd at one moment and cash to hold it.

Take: don't build anything that only works with a crowd or a prize fund.

QuizUp (died March 2021)

Millions of players, thousands of topics, and no reason to come back once you'd beaten your friends. Bought, then shut.

Take: breadth isn't retention. A reason to return each day is.

Sporcle

Deep, typed answers, huge back catalogue, a real community of makers. The interface is dated and the ads are loud, and people stay anyway.

Take: depth of content outlives interface fashion. Our answer is content that teaches, not more features.

Brilliant

Explanations built as interactive steps, not paragraphs. Expensive, and people pay because they feel themselves getting better.

Take: the explanation is the product. Ours are good and should get more room, not less.

Quizlet and Anki

Spaced repetition: the boring engine under every serious learning app. Anki is ugly and beloved; Quizlet is smooth and shallower.

Take: bring back a question someone got wrong, later. We remember what a device has seen; we don't yet use it to teach.

Jeopardy! World Tour and Heads Up

Licensed formats with a social hook. Heads Up works because the phone faces away and other people shout.

Take: the phone can be an object in a room, not just a screen.

3. Every idea, unfiltered

Written without a filter on purpose. The ones marked **(far off)** aren't buildable now.

The object itself

1. Point your camera at an object and get its question **(far off)**.
2. Tap a hotspot on a photo to ask "why is this here?" and answer.
3. A "guess the object from three close-ups" round.
4. Turn a question into a physical card you can print.
5. Cross-sections you can drag apart.
6. Before and after: the earlier design next to today's, and why it changed.
7. A map of objects by country, so you can play "India tonight".

Playing

1. Hard mode: only the questions people get wrong.
2. Speed mode: sixty seconds, as many as you can.
3. Survival mode: one wrong answer ends it.
4. Two players on one phone, taking turns.
5. A room mode with a code on a big screen.
6. Challenge a friend with the same ten questions, and a result they can compare.
7. "Explain it yourself" answers, judged by a model **(far off)**.
8. Bet points before answering.
9. Let a player make a question and submit it for review.

Learning

1. Bring back a question you got wrong, a week later.
2. "You keep missing questions about safety." A small, honest weakness report.
3. A thread of related questions after a run, three deep.
4. Save a question to read later.

5. A short weekly email: the three questions you missed.

Habit

1. The daily question (built).
2. Streaks with one forgiveness a month.
3. A calendar of the last thirty days, filled in.
4. A reminder you choose the time for, not one we choose.
5. A quiet week in review: what you learned, what you missed.

Social

1. A share card for the daily question that gives nothing away.
2. A weekly board (built), plus a board of friends only.
3. "Designers in Bengaluru" boards, by city (**far off**).
4. A comment under a question, moderated (**far off**).
5. A badge for spotting a genuine mistake in a question.

Content

1. Sources shown as a stack you can open.
 2. A confidence dial the player can see (built as a label).
 3. A "what changed" note when a question is corrected.
 4. Guest weeks: a chair week, a signage week.
 5. A question written by a designer, with their name on it.
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4. Frameworks

Jobs to be Done

People open this for four reasons:

- **Ten idle minutes** ("give me something better than a feed").
- **A designer's itch** ("I should know why that is").
- **Proof** ("I want to see that I'm good at this").
- **Something to pass on** ("that fact is worth telling someone").

The quiz serves the first two well, the third weakly, the fourth not at all.

Hooked

- **Trigger:** external is missing (no reminder, no notification). Internal is strong for designers: noticing an object.

- **Action:** low effort. Start, tap, read. Good.
- **Reward:** variable, because the reason is a surprise. This is our best asset.
- **Investment:** thin. A score, a streak, a name. Nothing accumulates that a player would miss.

Octalysis

Strong on curiosity and accomplishment. Weak on ownership (nothing to build up), social influence (no friends), and meaning (no sense of a bigger project). Loss avoidance is now present through the streak, and should not be pushed further.

Kano

- **Expected:** it works on a phone, it's fast, scores are right, no broken images.
- **Performance:** more questions, better images, sharper explanations. More is better, up to a point.
- **Delight:** the reason itself when it lands, the wall of whys, a share card, a weakness report.

RICE

Reach times impact times confidence, divided by effort. Used to order the list below.

5. Insights

1. **The reason is the product.** Everything else is packaging. Anything that makes reasons better or more numerous beats a new mode.
 2. **Nothing accumulates.** A player has a score and a streak. There is no collection, no map, no record of what they learned. That's the biggest hole.
 3. **No reason to come back except the daily question.** That is exactly what killed QuizUp, and exactly what the daily question is for. It's enough for now, and it's fragile: keep the queue full.
 4. **Nothing leaves the app.** No share card, no result worth sending. Wordle's grid was most of its growth.
 5. **We teach nothing twice.** We know which questions a device has seen and got wrong; we never bring them back.
 6. **The content bank is the bottleneck.** With 64 live questions, a keen player exhausts it in about six runs. Every engagement feature makes this worse, so writing questions is a growth feature.
 7. **Choice earns its keep.** Topics turn "ten random questions" into "ten I chose", and it costs nothing to offer.
 8. **Speed scoring fights the point.** Points for answering fast push people past the reasoning, which is the thing worth reading. Worth watching in the numbers now that we can see time to answer.
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6. What to build, in order

#	What	Why	Size
1	Keep writing questions (with CEED as a source)	The bottleneck behind everything else	Ongoing
2	Share card for the daily question	The only feature here that brings new players, and Wordle proved the shape	Small
3	Bring back what you missed	Turns a quiz into learning; uses data we already keep	Small
4	"What you learned this week" on the home screen	Gives the player something that accumulates	Medium
5	Hard mode (see <code>later.md</code> for the shape)	A reason to return for the people who finish everything	Medium
6	Challenge a friend with the same ten	Social pull without accounts: a link carries the run	Medium
7	A reminder the player sets	An external trigger they chose, not one we imposed	Medium
8	Save a question	Cheap, and it feeds the weekly review	Small
9	Player-submitted questions into the review queue	Content at scale, and the builder already reviews	Medium
10	Room mode (big screen, join code)	Workshops and classrooms; a different product, worth its own decision	Large

Deliberately not on the list: badges for their own sake, hearts or lives, anything that punishes a mistake, and streak pressure beyond one gentle line.

7. Persona prompts

Each prompt is for an agent (or a person) with no knowledge of the answers. Give it one persona, let it play ten questions plus the daily question, and ask for the report at the end. Scores are only meaningful if the player hasn't seen the answer key.

Prompt A: the non-designer

You have never studied design. You notice things, but you have no vocabulary for them and no history of furniture, typography or interfaces. Play a ten question run at {URL}, then today's question on the home screen.

For each question: say what you'd answer and why, in one sentence, before you see the result. Reason only from everyday experience, never from knowledge you'd have to be a designer to hold. If a question uses a word or name you wouldn't know, say so.

At the end report: how many you got right; which questions you couldn't reason about at all and why; anything on screen you didn't understand; the moment you most wanted to leave; and the moment that made you want one more.

Prompt B: the beginner designer

You are two years into design work. You know the famous chairs by picture but not by story, you know interface conventions from using them, and you have opinions you can't fully defend. Play a ten question run at {URL}, then today's question.

For each question: state your answer and the reasoning before the result. Say when you're guessing from a half-remembered fact, and when you're reasoning from the object itself.

At the end report: how many you got right; which explanations taught you something you didn't know; which felt obvious; whether the hint was worth the ten second cost; and what you'd tell a friend about this app in one line.

Prompt C: the ten year veteran

You have shipped design work for a decade. You know the history, the literature and the usual myths, and you're hard to impress. Play a ten question run at {URL}, then today's question.

For each question: answer, then judge the question itself: is it well posed, are the wrong options plausible, is the correct answer actually correct, and is the source good enough for the confidence label shown?

At the end report: how many you got right; every question you think is wrong, over-simplified or badly sourced, with a specific correction; which questions a design student should be made to answer; and the one change that would most improve the app for someone like you.

Also worth doing: run the same three scripts with three real people. An agent can't be surprised, bored or annoyed, and those three reactions are what this quiz lives or dies by.

8. What to watch once it's live

The dashboard now shows all of this: how many finish a run, where they stop, the spread of scores, the hardest and easiest questions, which topics are chosen, how often hints and redeems are used, flags per hundred runs, and daily question answers with streaks. The numbers that would change the plan:

- **Completion under half:** the run is too long, or question three is too hard.
- **Daily answers higher than run completions:** the daily question is the product; build around it.
- **Hint rate under a tenth:** the hint costs too much, or nobody notices it.
- **A question under 20% right with high flags:** the question is wrong, not hard.
- **Returning players near zero after a month:** nothing accumulates. Build items 3 and 4 above.